Mehrdad Pourghasem

Fifth-Year PhD Candidate, Economics, Pennsylvania State University
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Available May–August 2027 | Open to relocation

Profile

Fifth-year Economics PhD candidate (expected 2028) in **empirical industrial organization** and **health economics**. I estimate structural models of firm bargaining and consumer demand on large administrative datasets to quantify how market structure and vertical integration affect negotiated prices and welfare—the questions at the center of antitrust and health care litigation. Four years of prior applied research experience scoping ambiguous questions and presenting technical findings to non-technical decision-makers.

Education

PhD in Economics, Pennsylvania State University 2022 – 2028 (expected)
Fields: Industrial Organization, Health Economics. Advisors: Conor Ryan, Paul Grieco.
Dissertation: *Who Chooses the Hospital? Insurers' Referral Steering and Hospital Prices.*

MSc in Economics, Sharif University of Technology, Iran 2022
Thesis: *Road Infrastructure and Agricultural Outcomes.* Ranked 1st in cumulative GPA in cohort; top 0.5% of 10,000+ nationwide graduate entrance-exam candidates.

BSc in Industrial Engineering, Sharif University of Technology, Iran 2019

Research

- **Insurer Steering Through Primary Care Physicians: Effects on Hospital Demand, Prices, and Welfare** *(job market paper, in progress).* Estimating a structural model of hospital–insurer **Nash-in-Nash bargaining**, household insurance choice, and patient hospital demand on **2018–2023 California claims and admissions data**, identified off staggered PCP contract transitions to capitation. Quantifies how insurer control of referral flows shifts bargaining leverage, negotiated prices, and welfare.
- **Why Pay-for-Performance Failed to Move the Needle: Incentive Pass-Through in the U.S. Dialysis Industry** *(working paper).* Explains why ETC, a mandatory randomized Medicare payment reform, had near-zero reduced-form effect on home dialysis. Built a facility-year panel of ~**9,000 facilities** from CMS claims and cost reports; estimated a structural model decomposing the null into eligibility constraints, investment costs, and **chain-level optimization across markets**; simulated counterfactual subsidies and payment rates.
- **Heterogeneous Willingness-to-Pay for Electric Vehicles.** Merged market-level auto sales (Ward's), household microdata (CEX), and vehicle attributes; estimated **random-coefficients logit demand (BLP)** with demographic interactions and micro-moments to recover willingness-to-pay and price elasticities by household segment.

Professional Experience

Research Analyst, Morvarid Petrochemical Company, Tehran, Iran Oct 2019 – Dec 2020
- Scoped broad strategic questions with the CEO into a structured analysis plan with defined milestones; led a 4-member team to deliver it.
- Built a dynamic forecasting model linking macroeconomic indicators to output and profitability; ran scenario analyses and presented recommendations to the executive team to guide long-term capital investment.

Research Analyst, Iranian Water Policy Research Institute, Tehran, Iran Oct 2017 – Dec 2018
- Evaluated competing regional water-market designs by combining stakeholder interviews with a structured review of international case studies; quantified the economic impact of alternative allocation rules, documenting assumptions, data sources, and limitations.
- Presented findings to 100+ stakeholders at a multi-day Chamber of Commerce forum, distilling technical analysis into clear options and trade-offs.

Earlier: **Research Analyst**, Urmia Lake Restoration Commission (2017); **Business Analyst**, Smartup Ventures (2016–17) — market research and feasibility analyses for early-stage ventures; promoted to CEO Assistant within six months.

Teaching

Instructor, Penn State — Intro to Macroeconomic Analysis and Policy (enrollment: 38) Summer 2025
Teaching Assistant, Penn State — International Finance; Advanced International Trade 2022 – present

Technical Skills

Programming & Tools: Python (pandas, NumPy, PyBLP), Stata, R, SQL, ArcGIS, Tableau, Power BI, LaTeX | **Languages:** English, Persian
Methods: Structural estimation (BLP demand, Nash-in-Nash bargaining, merger simulation), causal inference (DiD, IV, event study), panel data, large administrative claims data